

Yesterday 10:33 AM

This chat will be titled Picking a Character. Do you have some context as to what we're doing, the uni project?

I have **some** context, but not enough to honestly say I have the actual university assignment.

I know you're at **Trent University in the BSc Computer Science program**, and I know you've recently been dealing with the practical reality of the university experience. I also have substantial context around your reading—especially Dostoevsky and your interest in **character, psychology, morality, and ideas operating through characters**.

But I **don't have the specific assignment/project instructions** that you're referring to, nor do I have a stored record of what the character-selection component is.

So if this is the project where we're **picking a character to work with**, give me the assignment prompt (or paste/upload it), and I'll have the exact frame we're working inside.

No problem, I'll give you a quick summary or synopsis. By the way, I want you to briefly just tell me the difference between those words, and well, I know summary might be the right, might be maybe possible in this context, but synopsis, I've never really gotten a strong definition of that and the right use of it. Just a tangent, I would like to know. Anyway, quick summary. School started. I haven't been paid my OSAP. I found out Trent is a terrible school, at least in my opinion. Can't get through to anyone. OSAP might be coming in late, and I realized that my plan, although school was supposed to be some background

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Yeah. That gives me the context I need for where we're going with **Picking a Character**.

Summary vs. synopsis

They're close, but there's a useful distinction:

- **Summary** = a condensed account of the important points of something. It can be very broad and is useful for basically anything: a conversation, book, article, situation, plan, etc.
- **Synopsis** = a concise outline of the **main substance or storyline** of something, especially a book, film, play, paper, proposal, or other substantial work. It usually gives you the structure: *what is this thing about, what happens, and where does it go?*

So what you just gave me is most naturally a **summary of your current situation/context**. You could also call it a **synopsis of the situation**, but that's less idiomatic.

And the distinction becomes clearer with fiction:

Summary: "The novel follows a young man who becomes increasingly alienated from society and struggles with his ideas about reason, freedom, and human nature."

Synopsis: "A young man living in poverty becomes obsessed with the idea that rational self-interest should govern human behavior. He encounters people and situations that undermine this belief, eventually confronting the contradictions between his theories and his own irrational desires."

The synopsis tends to tell you the **shape of the thing**.

And yes, I understand the larger context now.

The important shift you're describing is that **school has changed categories**.

It was originally something like:

credential in the background while I build my actual life.

Now, because of the financial situation, the school's poor institutional experience, and the realization that you may be able to compress the degree into something like **April 2028**, you're having to consider:

If I'm going to be here anyway, I may need to extract actual labor-market value from this thing.

And that means the CS degree isn't merely "pass the courses and get the credential." It potentially becomes a **two-year-ish career-construction project** involving programming ability, projects, relationships/networking, employment, and managing your existing business/other ambitions alongside it.

That's a substantial change in the problem you're solving.

And I understand why the **"get a job as a programmer"** framing feels particularly foreign to you. It's not simply adding another task. It changes the strategic model of what you're doing with university.

So when we get into **Picking a Character**, I'll keep that whole situation in the background rather than treating the assignment as some isolated little school exercise.

Okay, so what do I want to talk about? Well, as you know, I'm very—I'm a systems—I'm really systems guy. Well, call it whatever you want to call it, autism, or, I don't know, whatever the hell it is. I'm not—I can be very fluid. I can be very socially fluid, in fact. But it's always been an act for me, because that's not natural. I'm a very solitary kind of person. So I realized that for me to succeed and go and build relationships, if I've never been successful at doing that, and I say never—I think that's, you know, fair to say. I've never really been successful. Well, I wouldn't now say never. I have been successful, and interestingly, when I

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Yes. I think I understand the project now, and more importantly, I understand **why you're calling it "Picking a Character."**

What you're describing isn't really "pretending to be someone else." It's closer to **deliberately constructing an operating identity for an environment you've historically found alien.**

And there's a very important observation buried in what you just said:

You don't have an image of yourself in the environment.

That's different from "I'm socially anxious" or "I don't know what to say." You're noticing something more fundamental: when you imagine the actual scene—the office, the people,

the camera, the casual interactions, the body language—you don't have a stable internal model of **yourself as a participant in it**.

So your brain can't simulate the character.

And because you think in systems, your instinct is naturally:

Observe environment → identify successful behavioral configuration → construct agent → run agent → iterate.

That's actually quite consistent with what you described about your earlier leadership experience. You weren't simply "faking" being a leader. You **adopted a different configuration of yourself**, behaved through it long enough that it became increasingly natural, and eventually you genuinely inhabited it.

That's the interesting part.

The video was useful precisely because it produced a negative signal

You weren't merely thinking:

"These people aren't like me."

You were asking:

"Where am I in this picture?"

And you couldn't find yourself.

That discomfort is therefore potentially useful diagnostic information. It tells you there is some missing mapping between:

environment → identity → behavior → belonging

You can investigate that rather than simply telling yourself to "network more."

And I think your idea of **building backward from the visible character** is particularly interesting.

Don't begin with:

"What personality should I have?"

Begin with:

"Put me in that room."

Then construct the observable person:

- What does he look like?
- What does he wear?
- Where does he sit?
- Who does he naturally talk to?
- How does he enter a room?
- What's his resting facial expression?
- How does he respond when someone approaches him?
- How does he speak to a manager?
- How does he speak to another developer?
- What does he do during an awkward silence?
- What does he do when he doesn't know something?
- What does he do when someone disagrees with him?
- What does he do when there's a group conversation?
- What does he do when he's alone?
- What does he actually care about?
- What does he **not** care about?

And then, crucially:

Why does this person feel at home here?

Because that's probably where the real character is.

The clothes, haircut, posture, facial expression, vocabulary, etc. are the **surface representation**. Underneath that is the model that makes all of those things coherent.

And I wouldn't assume the answer is "become more extroverted" or "become more corporate." It might be something much more specific.

Maybe the person you're looking for is quiet but extremely comfortable. Maybe he's intensely curious about the technical problem in front of him. Maybe he's socially warm but doesn't need social stimulation. Maybe he's the guy who can walk into a room of 20 people, say three sentences, make one useful connection, and go back to his work without feeling like he needs to perform.

You don't know yet.

That's what we're going to discover.

And I think the distinction you made at the end is important:

There is going to be someone where I go, "Boom. That's it."

Exactly.

We're not trying to invent an arbitrary persona and force you into it.

We're trying to find a **plausible version of you that already makes sense inside the world you're trying to enter**—then reverse-engineer that person.

That is a much more interesting project than "how do I network?"

The beauty about this is that it actually applies. It can also... not can also. It is the same thought. It is the same model to think through intimate relationships, though I won't lie. Well, intimate relationships is different from a marriage. I don't think I'm ever going to get married, but, like, intimate relationships, it is the thought models to think through that as well. There's a way of being, right? So I just want to put that out there because it's part of what I'm going to be doing in the study. Now, good. The way I am is I just need to solve it up to the point where I can see it being possible. Like I don't have to sit down right now and start

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Yes. And I think you've just identified something important about the distinction between **planning** and **modeling**.

Your plan didn't necessarily fail because you lacked discipline. The plan produced **new information about the system**.

You had a model:

Sunday → Monday → Tuesday → Wednesday → Thursday → Friday
with sleep, school, work, business, etc. allocated into the available space.

You executed it reasonably well for several days. Then the system started behaving differently from the model.

That is extremely valuable.

The question isn't immediately, *"How do I become more disciplined?"*

It's:

What variable did my model fail to represent?

And you've already identified one: **sleep wasn't an isolated block of time.**

You accounted for *sleep occurring*, but apparently didn't model sufficiently what determines whether sleep actually occurs at the intended time.

That's a completely different problem.

For example, if you say:

1:00 AM–7:00 AM — sleep

that's not actually a complete sleep model.

The real system might be:

11:30 PM — finish activity
↓
physiological/mental arousal
↓
transition period
↓
phone / thoughts / unfinished work
↓
actual sleep onset
↓
wake time
↓
accumulated sleep pressure
↓
next day's cognitive capacity
↓
ability to execute evening activities

Now the thing you're managing isn't **time**. It's a **dynamic system with state variables**.

And I think that's why you're saying:

"I haven't been rigorous in planning what those activities are."

Exactly.

You had something like:

TIME → ACTIVITY

But you need:

TIME + STATE → ACTIVITY

Because 8 PM on Monday and 8 PM on Thursday aren't necessarily the same resource.

One might be:

- high energy + cognitively fresh + socially available

and the other:

- four hours of commuting + school + accumulated sleep debt + mentally saturated.

Those are different states even though they're both "8 PM."

And this connects directly to the character idea

There's actually a common structure underneath both problems.

You're trying to construct a **working model of yourself**.

For relationships:

- What configuration of me can thrive in this environment?**

For professional/social environments:

- What configuration of me can thrive in this environment?**

For your schedule:

- What configuration of my week allows me to actually execute this life?**

In all three cases, you're not asking:

- "What should I ideally do?"

You're asking:

- "What system actually produces the desired behavior under real conditions?"**

That's much more useful.

And your point about needing to solve something only to the point where you can **see that it's possible** is also significant.

You don't necessarily need to execute the entire solution today.

If you can establish:

"I have a coherent model, the constraints are understood, and there is a viable path through them."

then your uncertainty drops enough that you can move on to the next bottleneck.

That's almost like **proof of feasibility before implementation**.

So I wouldn't frame your next problem as "time management."

I'd frame it more precisely:

Build a weekly operating model that remains executable when real human variables—sleep, fatigue, commuting, cognitive load, school, work, business, and unexpected events—enter the system.

And *then* we can look at why last week's plan broke at the exact point where it did.

That failure is data.

ChatGPT can make mistakes. Check important info.